Reading

Folk Culture and Folklore of Tamil Nadu

Tamil Nadu is deeply rooted in a great tradition of folk arts and crafts, which display the customs and skills that have come down from generations. The folk music and dances of Tamil Nadu represent the ethos, aesthetic, values and melody of the region. Traditionally, folk dances and music are performed during festivals and community functions. The following article describes some of the folk musical styles and dances of Tamil Nadu.

Karagaattam is a popular folk dance of Tamil Nadu, which involves balancing a pot on the head to musical accompaniment. The Karagam pots are decorated with a cone of flower arrangements, topped by a paper parrot. The parrot swings as the dancer swings along.



Karagaattam has two divisions — atta karagam and sakthi karagam. This form of dance is very popular all over Tamil Nadu. Both male and female performers participate in this dance. Acrobatics such as dancing on a rolling block of wood, moving up and down a ladder, threading a needle while bending backwards form a part of this dance.

Kavadi Aattam is one of the predominant folk dances of Tamil Nadu.



When the ancient Tamils went on pilgrimages, they used to carry offerings tied on either end of a long stick, balanced on their shoulders. A kavadi is made of bamboo strips and a light pole. To lessen the boredom of the long travel, they sing and dance in praise of God. Kavadi Aattam traces its origin to this practice. This led to the composition of special songs for carrying the kavadi.

Poikkal Kudhirai Aattam is a dance in which the dancer puts on the



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